

Environment & Nature

47 words · Environment & Nature

NOUNS

pollution

the presence of harmful substances in the environment

Air pollution in the city centre has reached dangerous levels.

recycling

the process of converting waste into reusable materials

Recycling rates have improved but are still too low.

drought

a prolonged period of abnormally low rainfall

The drought destroyed most of the harvest that year.

wildlife

animals and plants living in their natural environment

The reserve is home to a wide variety of wildlife.

biodiversity

the variety of plant and animal life in a habitat or region

Deforestation is one of the biggest threats to biodiversity.

ecosystem

a community of living organisms interacting with their environment

The oil spill devastated the marine ecosystem.

solar energy

power from the sun's heat and light, captured and turned into electricity or heat for use

The house runs almost entirely on solar energy.

greenwashing

marketing that falsely presents a company or product as environmentally friendly

The campaign was accused of greenwashing. The company still uses coal.

climate change

long-term shifts in global temperatures and weather patterns

Climate change is the defining issue of our generation.

waste

unwanted materials or substances that are discarded

The factory produces tons of industrial waste every year.

flood

an overflow of water that submerges normally dry land

The floods caused millions of euros in damage.

emissions

gases released into the atmosphere, especially from vehicles and industry

The country has pledged to reduce carbon emissions by forty per cent.

fossil fuels

coal, oil, and gas formed from ancient organic matter

We need to move away from fossil fuels as fast as possible.

deforestation

the clearing or removal of forests on a large scale

Deforestation in the Amazon has accelerated in recent years.

carbon offset

a reduction in emissions to compensate for emissions produced elsewhere

She paid for a carbon offset when booking her long-haul flight.

rewilding

the restoration of an area of land to its natural state

Rewilding projects in Scotland have reintroduced native species.

mother nature

the natural world personified as a powerful force

You can't fight mother nature. She always wins in the end.

ADJECTIVES

renewable

(of energy) from a source that is not depleted when used

Solar and wind are the most common forms of renewable energy.

organic

produced without artificial chemicals or pesticides

She only buys organic fruit and vegetables.

carbon-neutral

making no net release of carbon dioxide into the atmosphere

The company aims to be carbon-neutral by 2030.

pristine

in its original, unspoiled natural condition

The beach was completely pristine, not a scrap of litter.

endangered

(of a species) at serious risk of extinction

The polar bear is one of many endangered species.

sustainable

able to be maintained without depleting natural resources

Sustainable farming practices are essential for the future.

single-use

designed to be used once and then thrown away

Single-use plastic bottles are a major source of ocean pollution.

finite

limited in quantity; not infinite

Fossil fuels are finite. We will eventually run out.

VERBS

pollute

to contaminate the environment with harmful substances

Factories continue to pollute the river with chemical waste.

deplete

to use up or reduce a resource to dangerously low levels

Overfishing has severely depleted stocks in the North Sea.

recycle

to process waste so it can be used again

We recycle all our glass, paper, and plastic.

PHRASAL VERBS

cut down

to reduce consumption; also to fell a tree

They cut down the forest to build a motorway.

cut down on

to reduce the amount of something

More than I used to. I've cut down on meat and I try not to throw away food.

throw away

to discard something as waste

We throw away far too much food every year.

phase out

to gradually stop using something harmful

The government plans to phase out coal power by 2030.

use up

to consume all of a resource so that none remains

We're using up the earth's resources faster than they can be replaced.

wipe out

to completely destroy a population or species

Pollution has wiped out fish populations in several rivers.

COLLOCATIONS

go green

to adopt more environmentally friendly habits

More companies are going green to reduce their carbon footprint.

green space

an area of grass, trees, or plants within a town or city, used for recreation

The new housing development includes plenty of green space for residents to relax in.

a knock-on effect

an indirect, secondary result that follows from an action or event

Overfishing has a knock-on effect on the entire marine food chain.

food miles

the distance that food travels from where it is produced to where it is eaten

Buying vegetables that are grown nearby and in season cuts down on food miles.

carbon footprint

the total greenhouse gas emissions caused by a person or organisation

She calculated her carbon footprint and was shocked.

raise awareness

to help people understand an environmental issue

The documentary raised awareness of plastic pollution in the oceans.

the defining issue

the most important topic characterising an era

Constantly. It's the defining issue of our generation.

IDIOMS

the tip of the iceberg

a small visible part of a much larger hidden problem

The visible litter is just the tip of the iceberg.

a drop in the ocean

a very small and inadequate amount compared to what is needed

One country banning plastic bags is a drop in the ocean.

SET PHRASES

hear me out

used to ask someone to listen to your whole point before responding or disagreeing

Hear me out. Even short trips add up.

to put that into perspective

used to help someone grasp the true scale of a fact by comparing it to something familiar

The river rose almost two metres above normal. To put that into perspective, that's about as tall as a double-decker bus.

for all we know

used to say something might be true, although there is not enough information to be certain

For all we know, there could be thousands left to discover.

MODERN SLANG

tree hugger

a person who is passionate about protecting the environment (often mildly mocking)

He called her a tree hugger, but she took it as a compliment.